schools shows, females constitute a large proportion of those getting educated in the south.

No doubt such educational levels help explain why the Deccan is a key part of India's economic engine, as well as its gateway to the rest of Asia's vast trading network, with links throughout Southeast Asia and tie-ups to foreign corporations like Ford and Hyundai. Yet Sita will be part of that vibrancy for only a short while longer. If she wished, she could undoubtedly get that sales job and rise to become a manager, given the growth of business in places like Chennai and Bangalore. But that would mean turning her back on her parents. And from our conversation, it doesn't sound like she'd find a wide support group of friends who would either understand her choice or have taken the same road themselves.

The situation is not markedly different in cosmopolitan centers like New Delhi. While in the capital, I meet Aaliyah, a young, modern Muslim who is a reporter and anchor for one of India's large television stations. Like Sita, Aaliyah tells me that she's given in to her parents and agreed to an arranged marriage. She is far more negative about it than Sita, although her situation seems somewhat more palatable. Among Aaliyah's circle of female friends, some from work and some from university, many are not only married but also keeping their jobs. She is the same age as her prospective husband, who works in business. However, she has no interest in marrying him, especially after the usual one-and-only meeting of the families. What angers her most is that he is currently living overseas, so she will have to give up her job, though if he were in Delhi, she almost certainly would keep it. It may be only for a few years, she adds, but if she leaves India, she wants to do it for her own reasons, like getting a graduate degree in the United States.

Yet Aaliyah ultimately feels a responsibility to abide by her parents' wishes. Her parents are as traditional as Sita's and cannot conceive of her marrying a non-Muslim. I ask, probably impolitely, if he is an observant Muslim. "He's more traditional than I am," she remarks. "He prays twice a day, whereas I pray only once. Of course, we're both